AUDIT TRAIL AND MONITORING POLICY

POL-014 | Issued under the Information Management Framework

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IMPORTANT: This Policy contains the most critical technical controls in the IMF suite. The requirement that audit trail records are technically immutable — that no user, including a system administrator, can alter or delete them — is a regulatory baseline, not a recommended practice. Failure to meet this standard is a Critical finding in FDA, EMA, and MHRA inspections. Every GxP system deployed at [Company Name] must demonstrate compliance with Section 4 of this Policy before it may be used for regulated activities.

Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Description
0.1	[DATE]	[Author]	Initial draft
1.0	[DATE]	[Author]	Issued for review

1. Purpose

This Policy defines [Company Name]'s requirements for audit trails — the records that capture who did what, to which data, on which system, at what time — and for the monitoring programme that turns those records into actionable intelligence.

Audit trails serve three distinct purposes simultaneously. They are a regulatory compliance mechanism — 21 CFR Part 11, EU Annex 11, GDPR, HIPAA, and SOX all mandate specific audit trail capabilities. They are a security detection mechanism — anomalous activity in audit logs is often the first evidence of a security incident or insider threat. And they are a forensic resource — in the event of an incident, regulatory investigation, or litigation, audit trail records are the evidence that establishes what happened and when.

An audit trail that can be altered — by anyone, for any reason — serves none of these purposes. The foundational requirement of this Policy is that audit trail records are technically protected against modification or deletion from the moment they are created. This is non-negotiable for GxP systems and strongly required for all others.

> **IMPORTANT:** The single most common Critical data integrity finding in regulatory inspections globally is the ability of a system administrator — or in some cases ordinary users — to alter, delete, or suppress audit trail records. This is not a configuration oversight that can be remediated with a training record. It is a fundamental control failure that must be addressed by technical means: write-once storage, cryptographic audit log protection, or equivalent. Documented procedures prohibiting alteration are not a substitute for technical controls.

2. Scope

This Policy applies to all information systems classified under POL-005, with requirements scaled by criticality tier and regulatory flags. The scope of audit trail requirements covers:

- GxP-flagged systems (Track A per POL-006): the most stringent requirements. Audit trails for GxP systems are regulatory evidence. Every requirement in this Policy applies in full.
- SOX-scoped systems: audit trails for ITGC purposes. Requirements in Section 5.2 apply.
- Tier 1 and Tier 2 systems without a regulatory flag: security audit trail requirements in Section 5.3 apply.
- Tier 3 and Tier 4 systems: minimum logging requirements in Section 5.4 apply.

The Policy applies to all systems regardless of hosting model — on-premises, cloud, SaaS, or vendor-managed. For vendor-hosted systems, the vendor's audit trail capability must be assessed as part of the vendor qualification (POL-013) and must meet the standards defined in this Policy for the system's tier and regulatory flags.

3. Audit Trail Content — What Must Be Recorded

The content of an audit trail record is what makes it useful as evidence. A record that captures 'a change was made' is significantly less valuable than one that captures who made the change, what it was before and after, and the exact timestamp. The following content requirements apply.

3.1 Mandatory Content for All Systems (Minimum Standard)

Field	Description	Why It Matters
User identity	The unique identifier of the user account that performed the action. Must be a named individual account — not a shared account, generic account, or system account without an identified owner.	Satisfies the Attributable principle of ALCOA+. Without individual user identity, the record is not audit-trail compliant.
Timestamp	Date and time of the action, with timezone recorded. Precision: minimum seconds for GxP systems; milliseconds recommended.	Establishes the sequence of events. Timestamps must be server-generated — not client-generated — to prevent manipulation.
Event type	The category of action recorded: login, logout, data creation, data modification, data deletion, access attempt (successful and failed), configuration change, account change.	Enables efficient search and anomaly detection.
Object affected	The specific record, file, configuration parameter, or data element that was acted upon. Identified by the system's own unique identifier where available.	Allows the scope of any incident or investigation to be determined precisely.
Outcome	Whether the action succeeded or failed.	Failed actions — especially repeated failed logins or failed access attempts — are as significant as successful ones.

3.2 Additional Mandatory Content for GxP Systems (21 CFR Part 11 §11.10(e) / Annex 11 §9)

IMPORTANT: These additional fields are regulatory requirements for GxP systems, not recommendations. Absence of any of these fields in an audit trail record renders that record non-

compliant with 21 CFR Part 11 and EU Annex 11.

Field	Regulatory Basis	Description
Original value (before)	Part 11 §11.10(e); Annex 11 §9	For every data modification: the value of the field before the change was made. 'Changed' without 'changed from X to Y' is insufficient.
New value (after)	Part 11 §11.10(e); Annex 11 §9	For every data modification: the value of the field after the change was made.
Reason for change	Annex 11 §9; ICH Q10	Where the system supports it: the reason entered by the user for making the change. For GxP data, reason for change is expected — particularly for corrections to recorded values.
Electronic signature reference	Part 11 §11.10(e)	Where an electronic signature is applied to a record: the audit trail must link the signature event to the record signed, with signature date/time, signer identity, and signature meaning.
System-generated timestamp (server time)	Part 11 §11.10(e)	Timestamps must be generated by the system clock — not entered by users. Server time synchronisation to a reliable time source (NTP) must be confirmed in the validation.

3.3 Security-Specific Audit Trail Content (All Tier 1/2 and GxP/SOX Systems)

Event Category	Events to Be Recorded
Authentication events	All login attempts (successful and failed) with source IP; account lockouts; MFA events; session start and end with duration.
Access control events	Account creation, modification, and deletion; role / permission changes; access grant and revocation; failed access attempts to resources.
Privileged access events	All privileged session activity (per POL-009); privileged account activations; break-glass account access; service account logins.
Configuration changes	Changes to system configuration, security settings, network rules, audit trail configuration itself. The audit trail of changes to the audit trail configuration is particularly critical.
Data export and download	Bulk data export, download, or transmission events — especially for systems holding personal data or GxP records.

4. Audit Trail Integrity — Immutability

The integrity of audit trail records is the most important property they possess. An audit trail that can be altered is evidence that can be fabricated. An audit trail that can be deleted is evidence that can be suppressed. Neither serves its regulatory, security, or forensic purpose.

4.1 Technical Immutability Requirements

Requirement	System Scope	Implementation Standard
Audit trail records cannot be modified after creation — by any user, including system administrators	GxP (mandatory), Tier 1 (mandatory), Tier 2 (mandatory), Tier 3/4 (strongly recommended)	Technical controls must prevent modification. Acceptable implementations: write-once (WORM) storage; append-only database tables with no UPDATE/DELETE permissions for any role including DBA; cryptographic hash chaining of audit log entries (each record's hash includes the previous record's hash, making any modification detectable); immutable cloud audit log services (e.g., AWS CloudTrail with S3 Object Lock, Azure Immutable Blob Storage).
Audit trail records cannot be deleted — by any user, including system administrators	GxP (mandatory — records must be retained for full GxP retention period); Tier 1/2 (mandatory — records retained per POL-002 schedule)	No DELETE permission on audit trail tables for any database role. WORM storage with retention lock. Retention period locked to meet POL-002 requirements. Deletion attempted on immutable storage must generate an alert.
Audit trail configuration changes are themselves audited	All systems with audit trail capability	Any change to audit trail settings — enabling/disabling, changing scope, modifying retention — must itself be recorded in the audit trail and must not be possible to retroactively remove. Audit trail configuration is governed by POL-007 change management.
Audit trail accessibility to investigators and regulators	GxP and SOX systems	Audit trail records must be accessible in a human-readable form — not only in proprietary binary formats requiring vendor tooling. Export capability to standard formats (CSV, PDF, XML) must be available and must be validated as part of the OQ for GxP systems.
Audit trail completeness monitoring	GxP (mandatory), Tier 1/2 (mandatory)	Gaps in audit trail records — periods where no events are recorded in an active system — must be detected and investigated. Monitoring must alert within 4 hours of a gap being detected on a GxP or Tier 1 system.

IMPORTANT: A documented procedure that prohibits administrators from altering audit trail records is not equivalent to a technical control that makes alteration impossible. Inspectors are trained to test whether the audit trail is actually immutable — not merely whether there is a policy saying it should be. The question 'can you show me what happens when an administrator tries to delete an audit trail record?' should have a technically demonstrable answer.

4.2 Time Synchronisation

Audit trail timestamps are only meaningful if they are accurate and consistent across systems. Time synchronisation is a prerequisite for audit trail reliability.

- All servers, applications, and infrastructure components must synchronise their clocks to a reliable NTP (Network Time Protocol) source
- NTP synchronisation must be monitored — clock drift beyond 1 second on GxP or Tier 1 systems must generate an alert
- The NTP configuration and synchronisation status of GxP systems must be validated as part of the IQ/OQ qualification
- Audit trail records must record timestamps in UTC to avoid ambiguity during daylight saving time transitions — local time display may be used in the user interface, but UTC must be stored

5. Audit Trail Requirements by System Type

5.1 GxP Systems — Full Requirements (21 CFR Part 11 / EU Annex 11)

Requirement	Obligation
Scope of audit trail (Part 11 §11.10(e); Annex 11 §9)	The audit trail must capture all activity that creates, modifies, or deletes GxP records. The audit trail must be enabled for the system as a whole — not just for selected fields or selected users. Selective audit trail coverage is non-compliant.
Audit trail cannot be disabled by users (Part 11 §11.10(e))	The system must technically prevent any user — including administrators — from disabling the audit trail. If the audit trail can be disabled, this is a Critical finding. Acceptable: system-level audit trail configuration locked behind the POL-007 change management process.
Audit trail review (Part 11 §11.10(e); Annex 11 §9)	Audit trail records must be reviewed as a routine quality activity — not only in response to incidents. The review frequency, scope, and documentation requirements are defined in SOP-003. Review records are GxP quality records.
Audit trail retention (21 CFR Part 211.68; Annex 11 §17)	Audit trail records must be retained for the life of the system plus the applicable GxP retention period. Minimum: the longer of 5 years, or 1 year past the expiry date of the last batch produced using the system (for manufacturing systems). Clinical trial systems: retain per ICH E6 / applicable trial protocol (typically 15–25 years). Consult Compliance / QA for system-specific retention periods.
Audit trail included in system validation (Part 11 §11.10(e); Annex 11 §9)	The audit trail capability must be validated as part of the Track A qualification programme under POL-006. OQ testing must confirm: (a) all required fields are captured; (b) the record is immutable; (c) the audit trail cannot be disabled; (d) timestamps are accurate (NTP-synchronised); (e) the audit trail is accessible in a readable format.
Audit trail available for inspection (Part 11 §11.10(e))	Audit trail records must be available for review by regulatory inspectors without prior notice. The procedure for presenting audit trail records to an inspector must be documented and tested. The format must be human-readable — not requiring vendor-specific tooling to interpret.

5.2 SOX In-Scope Systems — ITGC Audit Trail Requirements

SOX-scoped systems require audit trail records that demonstrate ITGC controls are operating effectively. The following events must be captured and retained for 7 years per POL-002:

- All user access grants, modifications, and revocations — supporting quarterly access review evidence
- All privileged access events — supporting privileged access review evidence
- All change events — supporting change management ITGC evidence

- All financial transaction events — supporting the completeness and accuracy of financial reporting
- All failed login attempts and account lockout events — security monitoring evidence

SOX audit trail records must be available to Internal Audit and external auditors for sampling as part of annual ITGC testing. The audit trail must be complete and unaltered — any gap or evidence of modification is a potential control deficiency.

5.3 Tier 1 / Tier 2 Systems — Security Audit Trail Requirements

All Tier 1 and Tier 2 systems without a specific GxP or SOX flag must still maintain security-grade audit trails covering:

- All authentication events (login, logout, failed login, lockout)
- All access control changes (account creation, modification, deletion, permission changes)
- All privileged access events per POL-009
- All configuration changes
- Data access events for Confidential and above classified data

Audit trail records for Tier 1/2 systems are retained for 3 years minimum per POL-002, or longer where a security incident or legal hold requirement applies.

5.4 Tier 3 / Tier 4 Systems — Minimum Logging Requirements

Tier 3 and Tier 4 systems must maintain at minimum:

- Authentication events (login success/failure)
- Account administration events (creation, deletion, password reset)
- Application error logs sufficient to support incident investigation

Minimum logs for Tier 3/4 systems are retained for 12 months, or longer if the system is involved in an open incident or legal hold.

6. Centralised Log Management (SIEM)

Audit trail and security log records from all Tier 1 and Tier 2 systems — and all GxP-flagged and SOX-scoped systems — must be forwarded to the centralised SIEM (Security Information and Event Management) platform in near real-time. Local audit trail storage alone is insufficient for Tier 1/2 and GxP/SOX systems.

SIEM Requirement	Detail
Log forwarding	All Tier 1, Tier 2, GxP-flagged, and SOX-scoped systems forward logs to SIEM in near real-time (maximum 5-minute delay). Log forwarding failure must generate an alert within 15 minutes.
SIEM storage integrity	Logs stored in the SIEM are immutable — SIEM administrators cannot delete or modify ingested logs. SIEM storage meets the retention requirements of Section 5 for each log source.
Log parsing and normalisation	Logs are parsed into a consistent format enabling cross-system correlation. User identities are normalised to a single user identity where possible.
Alert rules	Information Security maintains a library of alert rules that detect anomalous and high-risk events per Section 7. Alert rules are reviewed and updated at least annually and following significant incidents.
SIEM access controls	Access to read SIEM logs is restricted to Information Security and authorised investigators. Access to SIEM configuration is restricted to senior Information Security staff and is itself audited. SIEM access is reviewed quarterly.
GxP log handling	Logs from GxP systems stored in the SIEM must meet the same immutability requirements as the system-level audit trail. The SIEM is not a substitute for the system-level audit trail — it is a complementary security monitoring capability. Both must be maintained.

7. Security and Compliance Monitoring Programme

Audit trail records are only useful if they are reviewed. The monitoring programme defines what is actively monitored, at what frequency, and what happens when anomalies are detected.

7.1 Continuous Automated Monitoring (Real-Time Alerts)

Alert Category	Specific Events	Response
Authentication anomalies	≥ 5 failed logins to the same account within 10 minutes; login from an impossible geography (same account,	Automatic account lockout. Alert to Information Security within 5 minutes. Investigated within 4 hours.

Alert Category	Specific Events	Response
	two locations within a physically impossible travel time); login outside normal hours from a new device	
Privileged access anomalies	Break-glass account activated; privileged session outside approved maintenance window; privileged access to GxP system without open change record; service account used for interactive login (per POL-009)	Immediate CISO alert. Investigated within 1 hour. GxP systems: Compliance / QA notified.
Audit trail integrity	Audit trail gap on GxP or Tier 1 system (period with no records from an active system); attempted deletion of audit trail record; audit trail configuration changed outside POL-007 change record	Immediate DIO and CISO alert. Treated as potential data integrity incident under SOP-003 and security incident under POL-012 simultaneously. Investigated within 1 hour.
Data exfiltration indicators	Bulk download or export of Tier 4 / GxP records; large-volume file transfer to unrecognised destination; upload to unapproved cloud storage from a GxP system	Information Security alert within 15 minutes. DPO notified if personal data involved. GDPR clock assessment initiated.
Vulnerability exploitation indicators	Known exploit signatures in application logs; SQL injection patterns; privilege escalation attempts	Immediate Information Security alert. POL-012 P1/P2 incident assessment within 30 minutes.

7.2 Periodic Audit Trail Reviews

Review Type	Frequency	Scope	Responsible	Evidence
GxP system audit trail review (per SOP-003)	Frequency per SOP-003 (minimum quarterly for Tier 1 GxP; semi-annual for Tier 2 GxP)	Review of all data creation, modification, and deletion events. Identify unexplained changes, missing reason-for-change entries, out-of-sequence records, or records with implausible timestamps.	DIO / Quality Reviewer per SOP-003	Review record in QMS. Signed by reviewer and DIO. Retained as GxP quality record.
Security access review	Quarterly (Tier	Review of access	System Owner /	Review record in

Review Type	Frequency	Scope	Responsible	Evidence
(integrated with POL-008 access reviews)	1/GxP/SOX); semi-annual (Tier 2); annual (Tier 3/4)	grant/revocation records. Confirm no accounts granted access outside the approved provisioning process. Review failed access patterns for anomalies.	Information Security	ITSM. Retained per POL-002.
Privileged access review (per POL-009)	Monthly (Tier 1/GxP/SOX); quarterly (Tier 2); semi-annual (Tier 3)	Review of all privileged session events. Confirm all sessions correspond to approved change records or approved maintenance windows. Review session durations and commands for anomalies.	CISO / Information Security	Review record. Retained per POL-002.
SOX ITGC audit trail review	Quarterly (aligned with SOX testing cadence)	Review of change management, access control, and financial transaction audit records. Confirm completeness and no evidence of modification.	Information Security / Internal Audit	Review record retained as SOX evidence — 7 years.
Annual comprehensive log review	Annual (ISRA input)	Cross-system review of logging completeness: confirm all in-scope systems are forwarding to SIEM; confirm no logging gaps; confirm alert rule coverage is current.	Information Security (CISO)	ISRA evidence.

8. Audit Trail Retention

Audit trail retention requirements are governed by POL-002 (Data Retention and Disposal Policy), supplemented by the specific requirements below. Audit trail records must be retained for at least the periods specified — they may not be deleted before the applicable retention period expires, regardless of storage cost.

System / Record Type	Minimum Retention	Governing Requirement	Notes
GxP system audit trail records	Life of system + applicable GxP retention period. Minimum 5 years from last use.	21 CFR Part 211.68; EU Annex 11 §17; ICH guidelines	Consult Compliance / QA for system-specific requirements. Clinical trial systems typically require 15 –25 years. Batch manufacturing records: minimum expiry date of last batch + 1 year.
SOX ITGC audit records (access, change, financial transaction logs)	7 years	SOX Section 802; PCAOB standards	Must be available for external auditor sampling during and after annual SOX audit.
Security audit trail (Tier 1/2, non-GxP/SOX)	3 years	ISO 27001; organisational standard	Extended to duration of any open legal hold, regulatory investigation, or litigation.
GDPR-related access and processing logs	Duration of underlying personal data retention + 3 years	GDPR Art. 5(2) accountability; Art. 32	DPO confirms applicable period for each processing activity.
HIPAA audit logs (PHI access and disclosure records)	6 years from creation or last effective date	HIPAA 45 CFR §164.530(j)	
Security incident forensic logs	Minimum 7 years for P1 incidents; 3 years for P2/P3	Organisational standard; potential litigation hold	Legal must confirm retention for incidents with litigation potential.
SIEM logs (all sources)	The longest applicable retention period among the sources ingested	Composite of all above	SIEM retention configuration must be set to the longest applicable period.

9. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
CISO	Policy co-owner (security dimensions). Owns the security monitoring programme and SIEM. Receives critical monitoring alerts. Approves alert rule definitions. Reviews annual log coverage assessment.
Data Integrity Officer (DIO)	Policy co-owner (GxP data integrity dimensions). Owns the GxP audit trail review programme per SOP-003. Co-approves GxP system audit trail configuration in OQ. Receives GxP audit trail gap alerts immediately. Confirms audit trail compliance for regulatory submissions.
Information Security	Manages SIEM and log forwarding. Maintains and operates alert rules. Responds to monitoring alerts. Conducts periodic audit trail reviews. Maintains audit trail configuration change log.
Data Custodian (IT)	Configures and maintains audit trail at the infrastructure layer (OS, database, network). Ensures NTP synchronisation. Implements WORM or immutable storage for audit logs. Forwards logs to SIEM.
System Owner	Ensures the system's audit trail meets the requirements of this Policy for the system's tier and regulatory flags. Includes audit trail requirements in the URS for new systems. Confirms audit trail capability in vendor assessments (POL-013).
Compliance / QA	Validates GxP system audit trail capability as part of OQ (POL-006). Conducts or oversees periodic GxP audit trail reviews per SOP-003. Assesses audit trail gaps or anomalies as potential data integrity incidents. Confirms audit trail adequacy for regulatory inspections.
DPO	Confirms audit log retention periods for personal data processing systems. Assesses data access logs for GDPR accountability. Reviews access logs where DSR or GDPR compliance evidence is needed.
All users	Must not attempt to access, modify, or delete audit trail records. Any attempt to circumvent audit trail controls — including requesting an administrator to delete a record — is a disciplinary matter and a potential data integrity incident.

10. Related Documents

Document ID	Title	Relationship
IMF-001	Information Management Framework	Parent framework
POL-003	Data Integrity Policy	ALCOA+ principles (especially Attributable, Complete, and Original) depend on audit trails meeting the content and immutability

Document ID	Title	Relationship
		requirements of this Policy; audit trail adequacy is the technical implementation of data integrity policy
POL-005	System Classification Policy	Criticality tier and regulatory flags determine audit trail scope, content, immutability, retention, and review frequency requirements under this Policy
POL-006	Computer System Validation and Qualification Policy	GxP system audit trail capability must be validated in OQ as part of Track A qualification; audit trail requirements are documented in the URS; OQ testing confirms all fields, immutability, and inspector accessibility
POL-007	Change Management Policy	Changes to audit trail configuration are POL-007 changes; the audit trail of audit trail configuration changes is specifically protected under Section 4
POL-008	Access Control Policy	Access control events (account changes, permission grants) are a mandatory audit trail category; access review evidence comes from audit trail records
POL-009	Privileged Access Management Policy	Privileged session events are the highest-risk audit trail category; session recording requirements complement the event-level audit trail
POL-010	Information Security Risk Policy	Audit trail gap or immutability failure is a Critical IS risk under POL-010; monitoring programme findings feed the Risk Register
POL-012	Incident Response Policy	Audit trail records are primary forensic evidence for security incident investigation; audit trail preservation is a mandatory step in POL-012 Stage 3; audit trail gap or manipulation is itself a P1 incident
POL-013	Third Party and Vendor Risk Policy	Vendor-hosted system audit trail capability is assessed in vendor qualification; vendor must demonstrate audit trail immutability and accessibility; SaaS providers must provide audit log export capability
POL-015	IT Service Management and Operational Incident Policy	Operational incidents creating audit trail gaps require documented explanation in or alongside the audit trail; gaps during outages are ALCOA+ completeness issues
SOP-003	Data Integrity Process	SOP-003 defines the operational GxP audit trail review process; the audit trail review is the primary routine quality check for GxP system data integrity; review records are GxP quality records

Document ID	Title	Relationship
EXC-001	Exception Management Policy and Register	Audit trail exceptions are the most restricted category under EXC-001; audit trail immutability exceptions and exceptions allowing audit trails to be disabled on GxP systems are non-approvable per EXC-001 Section 5; any approved audit trail exception requires immediate ISSG notification
RACI-001	Roles, Responsibilities and Authorities	Audit trail and monitoring accountability across the organisation

11. Definitions

Term	Definition
Audit Trail	A secure, computer-generated, time-stamped electronic record that allows reconstruction of the course of events relating to the creation, modification, or deletion of an electronic record.
Immutability	The property of audit trail records that prevents them from being altered or deleted after creation, by any user including system administrators, through technical controls.
Log Forwarding	The automatic transmission of audit log records from a source system to the centralised SIEM in near real-time.
NTP (Network Time Protocol)	A networking protocol for clock synchronisation between computer systems over a network, ensuring consistent and accurate timestamps across the environment.
SIEM (Security Information and Event Management)	A platform that collects, correlates, and analyses security event data from multiple sources to provide real-time monitoring, alerting, and forensic capability.
Timestamp	A sequence of characters or encoded information that identifies when a certain event occurred, with precision to at least the second, and recorded in UTC.
WORM (Write Once Read Many)	A data storage technology in which data, once written, cannot be modified or deleted. Used to ensure audit trail immutability.
Audit Trail Review	A structured, documented examination of audit trail records to identify anomalies, unexplained changes, or evidence of data integrity failure or security incidents.

— End of Document —

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